The CRA Rules for All 6 Accounts

TFSA, RRSP, Spousal RRSP, FHSA, RESP, Margin and Cash: every limit, deadline, grant, deduction and trap, the Home Buyers' Plan, and what happens between accounts and brokerages, in plain English · 2026

These accounts do six different jobs. Your TFSA is tax-free, forever. Your RRSP lowers your tax today and is taxed when the money comes out. A Spousal RRSP gives you the deduction and your spouse the income later. Your FHSA is deductible going in and tax-free coming out for your first home. Your children's RESP collects government grants and grows sheltered until they go to school. Your Margin and Cash accounts are taxed every year, and a margin account lets you borrow. Each registered account has its own limits, and every limit belongs to a PERSON or a CHILD, not to an account. Your taxable accounts share one cost base across every brokerage. When the accounts sit at different brokerages, nobody sees the whole picture, so nobody warns you. These are the rules that matter, and how the tracker handles each one.

1. YOUR TFSA ROOM

Rule	What it means	In the tracker
One room per person	All your TFSAs at every brokerage share ONE contribution room. Each brokerage only sees its own.	Settings B24; TFSA room block.
Annual limit	$7,000 for 2026. Unused room carries forward. Someone 18+ in 2009 who never contributed has $109,000 in 2026.	Settings B23.
Withdrawals come back January 1	Money you take out is added back to your room on January 1 of the next year, never the same year.	"Room on Jan 1 next year".
Deadline: December 31	No 60-day grace period. A January contribution uses the new year's room.	—
Over-contribution tax	1% per month on the highest excess, until it is withdrawn (Form RC243).	Red message.
US dividends	15% is withheld and cannot be recovered in a TFSA.	Dividend Tracker note.
Who can contribute	Canadian residents 18 or older with a SIN. Room builds from 2009 or the year you turn 18, even without an account. Contributions made while a non-resident: 1% per month.	—
Everything inside is tax-free	Dividends, interest, gains and withdrawals never go on your return and do not affect benefits (OAS, GIS, Canada Child Benefit). Losses cannot be claimed.	Tax Summary: "Not taxed now".
Day trading	Frequent trading inside a TFSA can be taxed as business income.	Rules tab.
Successor holder	Name your spouse as successor holder: they take over the TFSA tax-free at death, without using their room.	—

Example. Your room on January 1, 2026 is $20,000. You contribute $7,000 to your Wealthsimple TFSA and $6,000 to your Questrade TFSA. Room left = $20,000 – $13,000 = $7,000, for both together. You withdraw $1,000 in September: your room does not go up this year, but $1,000 comes back on January 1, 2027.

2. YOUR RRSP ROOM

Rule	What it means	In the tracker
One limit per person	All your RRSPs at every brokerage AND the Spousal RRSP you pay into share ONE deduction limit, shown on your Notice of Assessment. It already includes unused room from past years.	Settings B31 to B33; RRSP room block adds both.
New room each year	18% of last year's earned income, up to $33,810 for 2026 ($35,390 for 2027), minus any pension adjustment.	—

Rule	What it means	In the tracker
The March 1 deadline	Contributions up to the 60th day of the next year (March 1, 2027) can be deducted on your 2026 return (Line 20800). A contribution on February 16, 2026 belongs to 2025.	Mar 2 → Mar 1 window.
$2,000 buffer	You can be over by up to $2,000 in your lifetime. Beyond that, 1% per month on the excess (Form T1-OVP).	Amber, then red message.
Withdrawals	Taxed as income (Line 12900) with 10%, 20% or 30% withheld (different in Quebec). The room never comes back, except under the Home Buyers' Plan (up to $60,000) and the Lifelong Learning Plan.	Tax snapshot.
US dividends	The Canada-US treaty exempts US-listed shares held directly in an RRSP from the 15% withholding.	Dividend Tracker note.
Age 71	Convert your RRSP to a RRIF or an annuity by December 31 of the year you turn 71.	Settings B9.
Carry the deduction forward	You can contribute now and deduct later, in a year when your income (and tax rate) is higher.	—

Example. Your 2026 deduction limit is $18,000. You contribute $2,000 at TD on February 16 (that counts for 2025), $6,000 at RBC on March 10 and $3,000 at TD on August 20, and $4,000 to the Spousal RRSP at Questrade on March 20. Counted against 2026: $9,000 + $4,000 = $13,000. Room left: $5,000, until March 1, 2027.

3. THE HOME BUYERS' PLAN AND THE LIFELONG LEARNING PLAN

Rule	What it means	In the tracker
Up to $60,000 tax-free	First-time buyers can withdraw up to $60,000 from their RRSPs (withdrawals after April 16, 2024) to buy or build a qualifying home. You and your spouse can EACH withdraw $60,000.	Type = HBP Withdrawal; Settings B39.
First-time buyer	You (and your spouse) did not live in a home either of you owned in the year of the withdrawal (excluding the 31 days before it) or the 4 years before. Special rules for a disability or a marriage breakdown.	—
Buy on time	You must have a written agreement to buy or build, buy by October 1 of the year after the withdrawal, and live in the home within a year.	—
Repay over 15 years	Repayments start the 2nd year after the withdrawal (the 5th year for first withdrawals from January 1, 2022 to December 31, 2025). Repay at least 1/15 a year: any shortfall is added to your income for that year. Designate repayments on Schedule 7; they are not deducted.	Type = HBP Repayment; HBP balance; Settings B40.
The 90-day rule	Money contributed less than 90 days before an HBP withdrawal may not be deductible.	—
With your FHSA	You can use an FHSA qualifying withdrawal AND the HBP for the same home.	Tax-free down payment.
Lifelong Learning Plan	Up to $10,000 a year and $20,000 in total for full-time training or education for you or your spouse. Repaid over 10 years.	Log as Withdrawal and note it.

4. THE SPOUSAL RRSP

Rule	What it means	In the tracker
Who is who	You (the contributor) put money in and claim the deduction on Line 20800. Your spouse or common-law partner (the annuitant) owns the account and is taxed when money comes out.	Account = Spousal RRSP.
YOUR room	Spousal contributions use YOUR deduction limit, together with your own RRSP. Your spouse's own room is not touched.	RRSP room block (both).
The 3-year attribution rule	If your spouse withdraws in the calendar year you made ANY spousal contribution or in the 2 calendar years after, the withdrawal (up to what you contributed in those 3 years) is taxed to YOU. Your spouse gets the T4RSP; you report the attributed amount with Form T2205.	Attribution block; Tax Summary.
The calendar year you paid	Attribution uses the year the money went in, not the year you deducted it. A February 2027 contribution deducted on your 2026 return is a 2027 contribution for this rule.	Settings B104, B105.
Exceptions	No attribution if you are living apart because your relationship broke down, if either of you dies, if you are a non-resident, or for the RRIF minimum payment. HBP and LLP withdrawals are not attributed.	—
Until your spouse turns 71	You can keep contributing to a Spousal RRSP until December 31 of the year your SPOUSE turns 71, even if you are older (you still need room).	—
Pension splitting	From 65, up to half of eligible RRIF income can be split on your returns (Form T1032). A Spousal RRSP still helps before 65 and beyond the 50% limit.	—

Example. You contribute $2,000 to Alex's Spousal RRSP in June 2025 and $4,000 in March 2026. If Alex withdraws $5,000 in 2026, all $5,000 is taxed to you (it is less than the $6,000 contributed in 2024 to 2026). If Alex waits until January 1, 2029, with no more spousal contributions, the withdrawal is taxed to Alex.

5. YOUR FHSA (FIRST HOME SAVINGS ACCOUNT)

Rule	What it means	In the tracker
Who can open one	Canadian resident, at least 18 and not past the year you turn 71, and a first-time home buyer: you did not live in a home you or your spouse owned this year or in the previous 4 calendar years.	—
$8,000 a year, $40,000 for life	Room starts the year you open your FIRST FHSA. Unused room carries forward, but only up to $8,000, so the most in one year is $16,000. One room for all your FHSAs.	Settings B108 to B111; FHSA room block.
Deadline: December 31	FHSA room is the calendar year. There is no 60-day window.	—
Deductible	Contributions are deducted on Line 20805 (Schedule 15). You can carry the deduction forward to a later year.	Tax Summary.
Qualifying withdrawal: tax-free	You are a first-time buyer, you have a written agreement to buy or build a home in Canada before October 1 of the next year, and you plan to live in it within a year. Request it with Form RC725.	Type = Qualifying Withdrawal.
Other withdrawals are taxed	Money taken out for anything else is taxable income (T4FHSA, Line 12905). Withdrawals never give room back.	Column Q note; Tax Summary.
The 15-year clock	Close your FHSA by December 31 of the earliest of: 15 years after opening your first FHSA, the year you turn 71, or the year after your first qualifying withdrawal.	Settings B114; FHSA timeline.

Rule	What it means	In the tracker
Not buying? To your RRSP	Leftover FHSA money moves to your RRSP or RRIF tax-free, without using RRSP room. It does not give FHSA room back.	Type = Transfer to RRSP.
RRSP → FHSA	You can move RRSP money into your FHSA. It uses FHSA room, is not deductible again, and never gives RRSP room back.	Type = Transfer from RRSP.
Over-contribution	1% per month on the highest excess each month, with no buffer, until removed by a designated withdrawal or a transfer to your RRSP.	Red message.
Cannot be pledged	Using an FHSA as security for a loan is taxed as if you withdrew it.	—
US dividends	15% is withheld and cannot be recovered in an FHSA.	Dividend Tracker note.

Example. You opened your FHSA in 2025 and put in $4,000. Your 2026 room is $8,000 + $4,000 carried forward = $12,000. You contribute $8,000 at Wealthsimple and $2,000 at Questrade: $2,000 left this year, $26,000 left for life, and $10,000 of room in 2027 ($8,000 + the $2,000 you did not use). When you buy, your FHSA and a $60,000 HBP from your RRSP can go into the same down payment.

6. EACH CHILD'S RESP LIMIT

Rule	What it means	In the tracker
$50,000 per child, for life	Per beneficiary, across ALL RESPs and ALL subscribers: you, your partner, grandparents. There is no annual limit.	Per-child block.
Two RESPs, one limit	RESPs at two brokerages for the same child share ONE $50,000 limit and ONE $7,200 CESG maximum.	Child column (E).
Over-contribution tax	Each subscriber pays 1% per month on their share of the excess, until it is withdrawn.	Red message.
Withdrawals never give back room	Contributions you take out still count towards the $50,000.	—
Not deductible	RESP contributions do not lower your tax. The benefit is the grants and sheltered growth.	—
31 and 35 years	Contributions are allowed until December 31 of the 31st year after the plan was opened. The plan must close by December 31 of its 35th year.	RESP timeline.

7. THE CANADA EDUCATION SAVINGS GRANT (CESG) AND OTHER GRANTS

Rule	What it means	In the tracker
Basic CESG: 20%	The government adds 20% of the first $2,500 contributed for a child each year: $500.	"CESG earned by this year's contributions".
Grant room carries forward	Every child earns $500 of grant room a year from birth (since 2007), even with no RESP. You can collect at most $1,000 a year, by contributing $5,000.	"Max CESG you can get this year".
Lifetime maximum	$7,200 of CESG per child.	"CESG lifetime left".
Last year: the year the child turns 17	No CESG from the year the child turns 18. No 60-day grace period: contribute by December 31.	Status: "No CESG (18+)".
The age 16 and 17 rule	CESG at 16 or 17 only if, by the end of the year the child turned 15, at least $2,000 was contributed (and not withdrawn) OR at least $100 a year was contributed in any 4 years.	Status: "Check 16–17 rule".

Rule	What it means	In the tracker
Additional CESG	An extra 10% or 20% on the first $500 a year, depending on family income. Not carried forward.	Log it as CESG.
Canada Learning Bond	Up to $2,000 for lower-income families: $500 the first year, then $100 a year up to age 15. No contribution needed.	Type = CLB.
Provincial grants	BC Training and Education Savings Grant: $1,200 once. Quebec QESI: 10% of contributions.	Type = Provincial Grant.

Example. Emma was born in 2015 and has received $3,500 of CESG. Her grant room by 2026 is 12 years × $500 = $6,000, so $2,500 is unused and she can collect the $1,000 maximum this year. You contribute $2,500 at Wealthsimple and $1,500 at RBC: $4,000 × 20% = $800. Contributing $1,000 more by December 31 collects the other $200. Liam (born 2019, $2,000 received) gets $500 on $2,500, and $2,500 more collects his full $1,000.

8. PAYING FOR SCHOOL

Rule	What it means	In the tracker
EAP: taxed to the student	Educational Assistance Payments (grants + growth) are income for the student, who usually pays little or no tax.	Type = EAP; tax snapshot.
EAP limit in the first 13 weeks	Up to $8,000 for full-time studies and $4,000 per 13 weeks part-time. No limit after 13 weeks.	—
Your contributions come back tax-free	A PSE withdrawal returns your own contributions while the child is in school.	Type = PSE Withdrawal.
If nobody goes to school	CESG and CLB are repaid. Contributions come back tax-free. The growth becomes an Accumulated Income Payment taxed at your rate + 20% (12% in Quebec), unless you move up to $50,000 of it to your RRSP or a Spousal RRSP and have the room.	Types = Grant Repayment, AIP.
US dividends	15% is withheld in an RESP and cannot be recovered.	Dividend Tracker note.

9. USING YOUR TFSA AS COLLATERAL

Rule	What it means	In the tracker
It is allowed	Income Tax Act s. 146.2(4) lets a TFSA be used as security for a loan. Using an RRSP or FHSA that way makes it taxable. Only the TFSA can be pledged.	Settings D13:D20.
Brokerage policy decides	Some brokerages count part of your TFSA value towards your margin buying power. The rate, and whether they allow it at all, is their choice: ask them.	Collateral rate per brokerage.
Extra borrowing power	TFSA value at that brokerage × its collateral rate.	Margin & Collateral, column J.
A margin call can reach your TFSA	If your margin account falls short, the brokerage can sell pledged TFSA holdings. The room used by that money only comes back next January 1.	Status column, warnings.
Room is not affected	Pledging is not a withdrawal and does not use or free up contribution room.	—
Never an RRSP	If an RRSP is used as security for a loan, the value pledged is added to your income (Income Tax Act s. 146(10)).	No RRSP collateral rate.

Example. Your Wealthsimple TFSA is worth $7,500 and its collateral rate is 70%: your TFSA adds $5,250 of borrowing power there. With a $4,600 margin loan, you are using 88% of it. A 20% market drop would cut that power to $4,200, below your loan, and a margin call could force sales in either account.

10. MARGIN INTEREST (LINE 22100)

Rule	What it means	In the tracker
Deductible	Interest on money borrowed to earn investment income in a taxable account (Income Tax Act 20(1)(c), Income Tax Folio S3-F6-C1).	Tax Summary, Line 22100.
No cap	Not limited to your investment income. Excess interest reduces your other income.	—
NOT deductible: borrowing for a registered account	Interest on money borrowed to contribute to a TFSA, RRSP, FHSA or RESP, or for personal spending.	Rules tab.
Break-even yield	A full year of interest at today's loan ÷ the value of your margin holdings. Your holdings must earn at least this much.	Margin & Collateral.
After-tax cost	About interest × (1 – your marginal tax rate, Settings B86).	Ultimate Dashboard.

11. TRAPS BETWEEN THE ACCOUNTS

Trap	What happens	In the tracker
Superficial loss through a registered account or your spouse	Sell at a loss in your margin or cash account and buy the same shares within 30 days before or after in your TFSA, RRSP or FHSA, or by your spouse (including in their own accounts): the loss is denied. When a registered account bought them it is lost for good (Income Tax Act s. 54).	Column Q flag (your own accounts).
Moving shares into a registered account	An in-kind transfer from a taxable account counts as a sale at market value. A gain is taxable; a loss is denied (s. 40(2)(g)(iv)).	Log a Sell, then a Contribution and a Buy.
US dividends in a TFSA, FHSA or RESP	15% is withheld and lost. In a taxable account you can claim it back (Line 40500, Form T2209).	Dividend Tracker note.
Losses inside a registered account	A loss inside a TFSA, RRSP, Spousal RRSP, FHSA or RESP cannot be claimed against anything.	Column Q note.
Spousal withdrawals too soon	A Spousal RRSP withdrawal within the 3-year window is taxed to you, not your spouse.	Attribution block.
Two RRSPs, one room	Your RRSP and the Spousal RRSP share your room. Two brokerages each see half the picture.	RRSP room block.
FHSA withdrawal that does not qualify	Taxable income, and the room never comes back. Check the conditions before you withdraw.	Column Q note.

Example. On April 7 you sell 80 BCE shares in your RBC cash account for a $420 loss. On April 21 you buy 30 BCE in your Wealthsimple TFSA. The loss is a superficial loss: it is denied, and it is not added to anything you can use later.

12. CAPITAL GAINS AND YOUR ACB (MARGIN AND CASH)

- **50% of a net capital gain is taxable** (Schedule 3, Line 12700). The proposed 2/3 rate was cancelled in 2025.
- **Pooled ACB:** identical shares in all your taxable accounts at every brokerage share one average cost. Each registered account is a separate pool and never mixes in.
- **Capital losses** only offset capital gains: carry a net loss back 3 years (Form T1A) or forward with no limit.

• **Collect slips** (T5, T3, T5008) from every brokerage for the taxable accounts, plus your RRSP and FHSA contribution receipts, any T4RSP (your spouse receives the Spousal RRSP one) and T4FHSA. The student gets a T4A for EAPs. A TFSA has no tax slips.

13. DIVIDENDS

Holding	In your TFSA or FHSA	In your RRSP or Spousal RRSP	In an RESP	In your Margin or Cash account
Canadian eligible dividend	Tax-free (FHSA: if withdrawn for your home)	Not taxed until withdrawn	Taxed to the student as an EAP	Grossed up 38%, federal credit 15.0198% of the grossed-up amount
US-listed stock or ETF (JNJ, VOO)	15% withheld and lost	0% withheld (treaty)	15% withheld and lost	15% withheld, claimed back as a foreign tax credit
Interest	Tax-free (FHSA: if withdrawn for your home)	Not taxed until withdrawn	Taxed to the student as an EAP	Taxed at 100%

14. MOVING MONEY BETWEEN BROKERAGES

Rule	What it means	In the tracker
Use a direct transfer	Moving a TFSA or RRSP (or Spousal RRSP) to another brokerage with Form T2033, or an FHSA or RESP with the receiving brokerage's transfer form, is not a withdrawal and not a new contribution. Grants move with the RESP.	Transfer Out + Transfer In.
Never withdraw and re-deposit	A TFSA withdrawal re-deposited the same year uses room again. An RRSP withdrawal is taxed (and a Spousal RRSP one may be taxed to you). An FHSA withdrawal is taxed and the room is gone. An RESP withdrawal re-deposited counts again against $50,000, and grants may have to be repaid.	Room blocks.
Each brokerage only sees itself	They will all accept a contribution, even if your total room is used up somewhere else.	All Brokerages column.

15. WHICH ACCOUNT FIRST?

• **RESP up to the full CESG.** A 20% grant is an instant return no other account offers: $2,500 per child a year, or $5,000 to catch up unused grant room.

• **FHSA if you may buy your first home.** Deductible going in and tax-free coming out: open it early, because room only starts building once it is open, and unused money can go to your RRSP later without using RRSP room.

• **RRSP when your tax rate is high now.** If your marginal rate today is higher than you expect in retirement, the deduction wins. Hold US dividend payers here (0% US withholding). Use the Spousal RRSP when your spouse will retire with less income, and contribute in December rather than January to start the 3-year clock sooner.

• **TFSA for flexibility.** Money you might need before retirement, or growth you want tax-free forever.

• **Margin and Cash accounts after the shelters.** Canadian dividend payers suit a taxable account best (dividend tax credit). Never borrow to fill a registered account: that interest is not deductible. Keep a buffer between your loan and your borrowing power so a market drop does not force sales.

• Your best order depends on your income, your plans for a home, your children's ages and your goals. This is general information, not advice.

KEY NUMBERS FOR 2026

Item	Amount
TFSA annual limit	$7,000
RRSP new room	18% of 2025 earned income, up to $33,810
RRSP over-contribution buffer	$2,000 lifetime (your RRSP and the Spousal RRSP together)
Spousal RRSP attribution	Withdrawals in the year of a spousal contribution or the 2 calendar years after
FHSA	$8,000 a year, $40,000 for life, up to $8,000 carried forward, 15-year limit
Home Buyers' Plan	Up to $60,000 per person, repaid over 15 years
Lifelong Learning Plan	$10,000 a year, $20,000 in total, repaid over 10 years
RESP lifetime limit	$50,000 per child
Basic CESG	20% of the first $2,500 a year ($500); up to $1,000 a year with unused room
CESG lifetime maximum	$7,200 per child
Canada Learning Bond	Up to $2,000 per child
Over-contribution tax (TFSA, RRSP, FHSA, RESP)	1% per month on the excess
Capital gains inclusion rate	50% (Margin and Cash accounts)
Eligible dividend gross-up / federal credit	38% / 15.0198% of the grossed-up amount
Superficial loss window	30 days before and after the sale

For educational purposes only. Not financial or tax advice. Rules summarized for 2026 from canada.ca (TFSA guide RC4466, RRSPs and other registered plans T4040, Home Buyers' Plan, Spousal or common-law partner RRSPs, First Home Savings Account, RESP, Canada Education Savings Grant and Canada Learning Bond pages; carrying charges, Line 22100; Income Tax Folio S3-F6-C1; capital gains; superficial losses). Ask your brokerage about its margin and collateral policy. Questions: hello@maplesheet.ca